every terror strike would be increasingly counterproductive for them. If Pakistan thinks it acquired nuclear weapons to nullify the conventional asymmetry in India's favour, they are mistaken. India is constantly improving and expanding the depth of our conventional response to their terror attacks, as illustrated from the strikes after Uri, Balakot and now Operation Sindoor. So, that's a major challenge for them.

Q. Did China actively support Pakistan in the conflict?
There are facts, reasonable assumptions and speculation. The fact is that nearly 70 per cent of Pakistan's military inventory today is of Chinese origin. It is also natural that original equipment manufacturers support equipment during wartime. Commercial satellite imagery is widely available today. Whether intelligence-sharing crossed into deeper operational cooperation is difficult to conclusively establish. There were instances that raised suspicions. For example, Pakistan appeared aware of some Indian land deployments, but that is more likely due to human intelligence. I do not believe China would open a classic second front during such a conflict. Support may come through technology, intelligence, cyber or strategic domains rather than through a direct land war. Any future India-China conflict is also likely to remain localised rather than escalate into a full-scale front-wide war.

> **"Post-Galwan, increased deployment, infrastructure and surveillance along the LAC have raised chances of face-to-face encounters, making confidence-building measures necessary with China"**

Q. After the 2020 Galwan crisis and the larger Chinese intrusions along the Line of Actual Control, what is the possibility of similar situations arising again? What has changed on the ground since then?
What has fundamentally changed is the density of deployment and the level of surveillance along the LAC. Earlier, deployments on both sides were relatively thin. Patrols would move through extremely difficult terrain—forests, mountains and remote tracks—and, often, the two sides would not even encounter each other physically. In those days, patrols would sometimes only discover signs that the other side had passed through the area—cigarette packets, food tins, rum bottles, markings or temporary indicators deliberately left behind to mark territory. Today, however, the situation is very different. Infrastructure has improved significantly, troop density has increased and technology has transformed surveillance capabilities. There are now sensors, cameras, UAVs and better monitoring systems. As a result, movement is detected far more quickly, and both sides are far more aware of activity along the frontier.

Q. What is the impact of this improved monitoring system at the LAC?
Because of this, the probability of face-to-face encounters has naturally increased. Any such interaction can remain routine and benign, or it can become tense, depending on the sensitivity of the area and the circumstances at that moment. That is why confidence-building measures (CBMs), protocols and disciplined military engagement mechanisms remain extremely important. At the tactical level, local commanders and patrols on both sides operate under pressure because every patrol seeks to assert its own territorial perception. Therefore, maintaining established protocols and communication channels is essential to prevent local incidents from escalating unnecessarily.



Q. Where do things stand today in terms of disengagement and de-escalation with China on the LAC?
Physical disengagement has taken place in many places, and troops have stepped back from immediate face-offs. The next stage is de-escalation and eventual de-induction of the large force levels that had been mobilised after 2020. Some movement in that direction has already taken place, particularly unilaterally on the Chinese side, where certain offensive formations have reportedly gone back to peacetime locations. However, a broader and formal understanding on force levels—similar to earlier agreements where military exercises and deployments were regulated through mutual notification mechanisms—is still evolving through diplomatic and military dialogue channels. Ultimately, if the situation continues to stabilise, force levels may reduce gradually and naturally as both sides assess that such large deployments are no longer necessary. But that process will depend on continued stability and mutual confidence on the ground.